The deception could not last for ever and was eventually discovered. The Portuguese fended off an attack and hastily sailed farther north in search of Kilwa, an island-city and port that was important enough to be known in Europe. However, they got lost and instead found themselves in Mombasa which was another important port-city. Unfortunately, news of their deception had already made its way up the coast and the Portuguese narrowly escaped being lured into a trap by the sultan of Mombasa.

Vasco da Gama pushed farther north. Along the coast, he made inquiries about Christians and about the kingdom of Prester John. At last he found himself in the harbour of Malindi, a port that had been visited by the Chinese treasure fleet eighty years earlier and was the source of two giraffes that had been taken back to China. The ruler of Malindi was under no illusions about the identity of his guests but was in need of allies against Mombasa. He, therefore, opted to welcome the Portuguese.

Alvaro Velho, one of Da Gama's soldiers, has left us a description of the part-Arab, part-African world of the Swahili coast. The larger port-towns like Mombasa and Malindi had houses built of stone and lime. The population was mainly black African, with a ruling class of Arab extract. The merchants were mainly Arab but some Indians continued to visit these parts despite the caste restrictions. Vestiges of this world can still be seen in the Stone-Town of Zanzibar, Tanzania. The island of Zanzibar remained a major source of slaves bound for the Middle East till the nineteenth century. It continued to be ruled by an Omani Arab dynasty, under British protection, till as recently as 1963.

A community of Indian merchants had long visited Zanzibar but, under British protection, many more went to settle down there. By the early decades of the twentieth century, there was a thriving Indian community on the island. The singer Freddie Mercury was born here into a Parsi family in 1946. His name at birth was Farrokh Balsara and the house where he spent the first few years of his life still stands in Stone-Town. In a bloody revolution in 1963, however, the Arab dynasty was overthrown, thousands of Arabs and Indians were killed and the island soon became a semi-autonomous province of Tanzania. Still, a small Indian community lives in